Nocturne

By Adam Rapp

SON: Fifteen years ago I killed my sister. There. I said it. . . I can change the order of the words. My sister I killed fifteen years ago. I, fifteen years ago, killed my sister. Sister my killed I years ago fifteen.

I can cite various definitions. To deprive of life: the farmer killed the rabid dog. To put an end to: the umpire killed the tennis match. To mark for omission: he killed the paragraph. To destroy the vital essential quality of: the dentist killed the nerve with Novocain. To cause to stop: the bus driver killed the engine. To cause extreme pain to: his monologue killed the audience. To slay. To murder. To assassinate. To dispatch. To execute.

You can play with tenses. Will kill. Did kill. Have killed. Will have killed. Would like to have killed. You can turn it into a gerund. Killing. There's a kind of progress with a gerund. If you conjugate in the past tense it's all the same. I killed. You killed. He, she, it killed. They killed. You all killed. We killed. There's no way around it.

Fifteen years ago I killed my sister. I was seventeen, she was nine. A fact.

INTRODUCTION

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SON: The accident happens like this: Joliet, Illinois. I'm coming home from Sub-Diggity, my summer sandwich-making job. My clothes smell like roast beef and mayonnaise. My fingers are stained with mustard. Steely Dan's *Hey Nineteen* is

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playing on the AM. *(Singing – see end of selection for a link to the lyrics and music of this song)* Way back when In Sixty-seven / I was the dandy Of Gamma Chi

It's the second week in July. I'm traveling west on Black Road. It's roughly ninety-five degrees. Mosquitoes are plotting their mid-summer feast. There's an endless feeling of Little League being played. Slurpies and caramel corn. Blue snow cones staining the chins of toddlers. Hot-dogs that are so good they can feed entire families. An ocean of Little League diamonds.

I tum south onto Gael Drive. *(Singing)* Sweet things from Boston So young and willing / Moved down to Scarsdale

I'm going forty-five in a thirty. At least that's where the speedometer freezes after the collision.

So, it's seven-thirty and the sun is a flaming orb on the horizon. There are colors in the sky. Reds. Pinks. Burnt oranges. Clouds like frayed gauze. Their underbellies golden somehow. Steely Dan is well into its chorus. *(Singing)* The Cuervo gold The fine Colombian / Make tonight a wonderful thing Say it again . .

I turn north onto Gael Drive and I decide to not go home. There's a place where I'll sometimes go and think. It's an enormous platoon of power lines. The radio trees. I want to take my shoes off and feel the buzz in my feet.

I accelerate. Something small runs out in the road.

I brake. Nothing happens. It's a dog. A garbage can.

A plastic bag that's stolen a bit of breeze. I pump the brake pedal. I swerve. There's a thud. A hollow, almost wooden thud. Small as an egg. I continue pumping the brakes. Nothing happens. Steely Dan turns into the Alan Parsons Project. *(see end of selection for a link to the lyrics and music of this song)* I am the eye in the sky.

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I pump the brakes and the Electra just keeps going as though by its own volition. I swerve. I counterswerve. I crash into a large oak tree at the end of the street. The front end of the Electra accordions to the windshield. Birds are everywhere. A schizophrenic cloud of crows.

I crack three ribs and break my nose. I can taste the metal in my blood. Like warm pewter. The speedometer sticks at forty-five miles per hour.

In that strange, post-crash ethereal silence, I get out of the car and walk the hundred yards or so back to where I heard the thud. The crows have formed a kind of wavering anvil and are flying south toward the sound of the highway. It feels as if the steering wheel has been inserted into my ribcage.

My sister's body lies in the street. It looks like a doll's body. Legs. Feet. Yellow socks perfectly folded. Bits of lace turned down-my mother's touch. Shoes so small it's as if they were born out of a children's fable. Hands. Arms. Neck. A small white dress with blue flowers. Anemones. Buttercups.

Her head is across the street. It has rolled into the Petersens' driveway. I walk over and pick it up. Simply. Perfunctorily. Only a feeling of great clarity and absence. Like a sudden gust of lake wind. As if it's a ball or some kind of fugitive picnic toy. Its weight seems tremendous. I will reattach it to the neck and she will rise off the pavement and go back into the house and wash up for supper.

As I'm reattaching my mother can be seen framed in the living room window, her hand pressed against the glass, her head slightly tilted as though she is peering out over a strange body of water; as though she is watching something hellish emerging from the fog.

The sound of sirens. Shrieking sirens from all directions. The shrieking turns

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into a kind of weeping. Sirens weeping in an octave only known to whales and dolphins.

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I can't remember my sister's face.

Other parts of her are as definite as forks and knives. Legs so slender you wonder how they could support the weight of even the smallest torso. Her wrists as thin as Popsicle sticks. Her boyish arms. Mosquito-bitten. Stained with iodine and calamine lotion. Her tiny hands. Her fingers as light and delicate as bird bones.

I try and reconstruct the images.

- Frame one: a dog; King-the Petersens' German Shepherd.
- Frame two: a bird; a spooked swallow swooping down from some unknown eaves; nose-diving into the grille at the threat of rain.
- Frame three: a small garbage can; green somehow; for recycling; and plastic because there's no music in the thud.
- Frame four; a mis-kicked football hurtling end-over-end from the Doughertys' back yard.
- And then frame five: My sister in her dress; her hand rising up theatrically.

Stop. Please stop. Not now. Not like this. I'm too small for this to happen.

She swam. She rode her bike. She liked boys' clothes. She'd steal my boxer shorts and wear them to swimming practice. Once at dinner she ambitiously announced her plan of owning a tuxedo. My mother, of course, made her wear dresses and pierced her ears.

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She proposed marriage to me at least once a week. She'd go to a knee and say, Marry me you big juicy hunk of yummy boy steak. I'm not kidding. She'd actually say that. And then she'd laugh and I'd laugh and the chorus of our laughter was like a jet flying through our silent house. . . She called me Dorkus.

So the memories are there. As clear as if they happened yesterday. I just can't see her face.

I wonder if she wanted to be hit. She wasn't chasing a ball or a kite. There weren't any kids calling to her from the other side of Gael Drive. She wasn't pushed from behind. From our driveway approaching cars can be seen at least fifty yards away.

No, she wasn't abused. She wasn't ridiculed. She was rarely, if ever, sent to her room. She was loved. And fed. She was well clothed. She was the first girl on her swim team to do the butterfly. In jacks she was good to sixes.

A faceless child walks in front of a speeding car. I could buy that. A man with three children and a beautiful wife leaps from the thirtieth floor of his Wall Street building. A pregnant woman walks off the Verrazano Bridge and everyone says she was so happy. But you never hear about it with children. It's always an accident

[But] perhaps there is a kind of deathwish in some children: I don't want to be an adult. I don't want to do that. I don't want to hide behind the drapes and darn my husband's socks. I don't want my belly to distend with multiple pregnancies or the disease of tumors.

I want to swim and run and spin. I want to get away with things. I want to eat snow cones for the rest of my life. So I'll end it while the going's still good. And I'll make it quick. I'll walk in front of a speeding car.

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The evening of my sister's death it was discovered that the brake line on the Electra had snapped.

I'm in the hospital when my mother walks-or rather glides-into my room. Her face hardened with grief. She sits in a chair beside me for a long time before she speaks. I look down and see that her hands are clenched into fists.

MOM: It was the brake line . . . They're going to let you off with involuntary manslaughter. The only thing you are guilty of is failure to stop to avoid an accident.

SON: She almost sounds disappointed.

MOM: A fifty-dollar fine. Your father paid it for you. . . He's taking it very hard.

SON: *(to Mom)* How are *you,* Mother? *(to audience)* She doesn't respond. Her eyes are screaming to blink. *(to Mom)* I'm sorry, Mother.

MOM: It wasn't your fault . . . Your father is taking it pretty hard, but we'll get through this. . . Rest well

SON: And then she gets up and walks out. That would be the last thing my mother would say to me: Rest well.

A month after the accident, she would move out of our little house on Gael Drive and into an apartment with her sister. She would live with my aunt for three years and then, one day, I would receive a letter from her sister saying that my mother had been moved to a private boarding residence for the clinically depressed. I would later learn of the daily diet of a hundred milligrams of Haldol and the bench where she spends most of her afternoons incessantly singing *Old MacDonald's Farm* and that her favorite pastime is the making of potholders.

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My father takes the death of my sister pretty hard. We haven't spoken since I've been home. I hover at the door to his study, leaning against the jamb. He can't look at me.

DAD: Come in, Son.

SON: I've lost my name. I enter his study. I sit across from him at his hulking oak banker's desk. His hands are flat on the blotter. His head tilted down, almost shamefully. There is a small snub-nosed revolver set between the axis of his thumbs. I have never seen this gun before. I had no idea that there's a small black gun living in our house. *(to Dad)* Dad, is that a gun? Dad . . .

(to audience) The gun is clutched between his hands now and its nose pointed at my throat. In a slow deliberate lean the gun gets closer and closer. I am thinking, "No, Dad. Please, no." But nothing comes out.

DAD: Don't move.

SON: The gun is in my mouth now. The cylinder forcing my lips apart. Like kissing the engine of a toy train. Its smell of axle grease. Its weight incredible on my teeth. My father seethes. His breath is hot and his skin is a flat dull pink and I don't recognize myself in him. I see nothing of his only son in this strange violent intimacy. . . . I hear my mother's voice.

MOM: *(gently with fatigue)* Earl. Put the gun down, Earl. . . Not this way, Honey.

SON: It's as if she is coaxing a child out of a tree. Not this way, Honey. What does that mean?

He would remove the gun from my mouth and my mother would take it and drop it in the trash, somehow rendering the thing powerless.

The taste of it still haunts me. Sickens me.

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I would eventually lift off the chair and walk out of our little house on Gael Drive. I would lurch/slouch/spiral to a bus stop. The bus would take me to the train station. I would arrive in New York City the following morning in a kind of severe, tightly coiled body clench.

Grand Central Station. A cathedral with noise. Anonymity.

Here is where I would begin my fifteen-year disappearance from the town with the little house on Gael Drive. I would step out onto Forty-second Street with twelve dollars and forty-two cents in my pocket. . . [because] Fifteen years ago I killed my sister. I was seventeen, she was nine.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

Steely Dan's Hey Nineteen - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ipc9pL27krs
Alan Parson Project's Eye in the Sky - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NNiie_zmSr8